



Fig. 101. Water system, sedimentation pool L67.

to the direction of the water flow, to stop stones carried along by it. During floods, workers at the site, too, were almost certainly engaged in filtering and removing stones swept along by water, and in cleaning the sedimentation pools and the channels.

Two additional pools are fed by the channel before it reaches sedimentation pool L69. The western pool L68 measures 2.93×2.39 m and is 1.66 m deep. Two staircases, to the east and west, descend to its bottom. The eastern staircase consists of five steps, and the western one, of four. Pool L68 was fed by a branch of the central channel that ran east of hall L77, directly to the pool. This branch, removed by de Vaux during his excavations, is not visible today. De Vaux surmised that this pool functioned as a

ritual bath. L70, the eastern pool close to L69, has a northern and a southern part. The southern one measures 3.05×1.38 m, while the shallower northern one measures 3.80×1.55 m. In his excavations of this pool de Vaux found yellow earth, which probably was a layer of fine potters' clay, the likes of which were found in pools L91 and L71 (see below). De Vaux suggested that this might have been the potters' workplace: the deep southern part used for storing the filtered clay, and the shallow northern one used for kneading it. Even if de Vaux's opinion is questionable, it nevertheless indicates that clay, the raw material for pottery vessels, was present in this pool as well. A channel exited the north of pool L70, connecting it with pool L71.

SITE DESCRIPTION

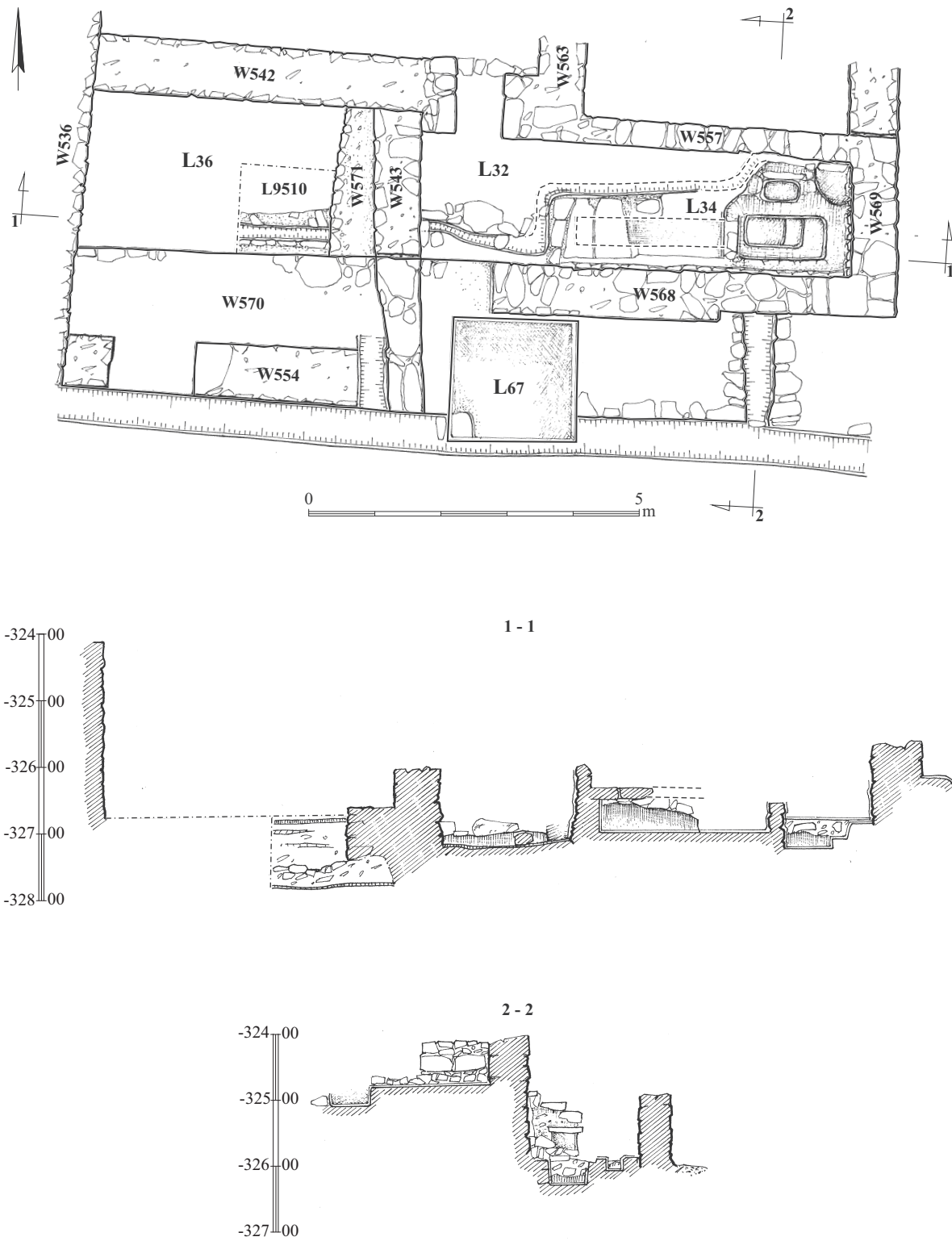


Fig. 102. Water system, plan and cross-sections, sedimentation pool L67.



Fig. 103. Water system, sedimentation pool L68 to right, L69 to left, L70 in center; view from the north.

Sedimentation pool L69, measuring 2.55×2.20 m and 2.30 m deep, south of L70 and west of pool L71, is the last sedimentation pool before the filtered water flowed to pool L71. There are stairs in its east, and the central channel entered it from the west. Water passed through a plastered 0.45 m square hole in the side of the sedimentation pool at a height of 1.90 m of pool L71's western wall.

As was noted, pool L71 is the largest one discovered at the site (Figs. 105–106). De Vaux only partially excavated it, and it was fully excavated in 2004 as part of the renewed excavations. Measuring 19.10×4.90 m and 5.40 m deep, it is built of large stones and is completely plastered (Fig. 107). A staircase descended the entire length of the pool to its bottom; some of the stairs are narrow, while others are wide. The pool excavation examined whether the clay needed to produce pottery vessels was present at its bottom. After prolonged excavations, we discovered a 20 cm-thick layer of finely filtered clay, from

which we collected about three tons of raw material for manufacturing pottery vessels. Moreover, we produced excellent ware from this clay, which had lain in the pool for two thousand years. This was decisive proof that the pools were not ritual baths, but were used for collecting clay needed for producing pottery vessels.

The central channel continues south of L68, parallel to L71's western wall. De Vaux excavated pool L75, (Fig. 108) west of the channel and south of L68. This pool is composed of a round basin and a square plastered platform, each connected to a branch of the central channel. De Vaux found fine clay on the latter part.

In summarizing the water system, we can say that the two phases, A and B, present in the main building and western structure, are also evident in the aqueduct and water system. In phase A, the narrow built and plastered aqueduct brought water from Naḥal Qumran to cistern L110 in the western structure. Within the

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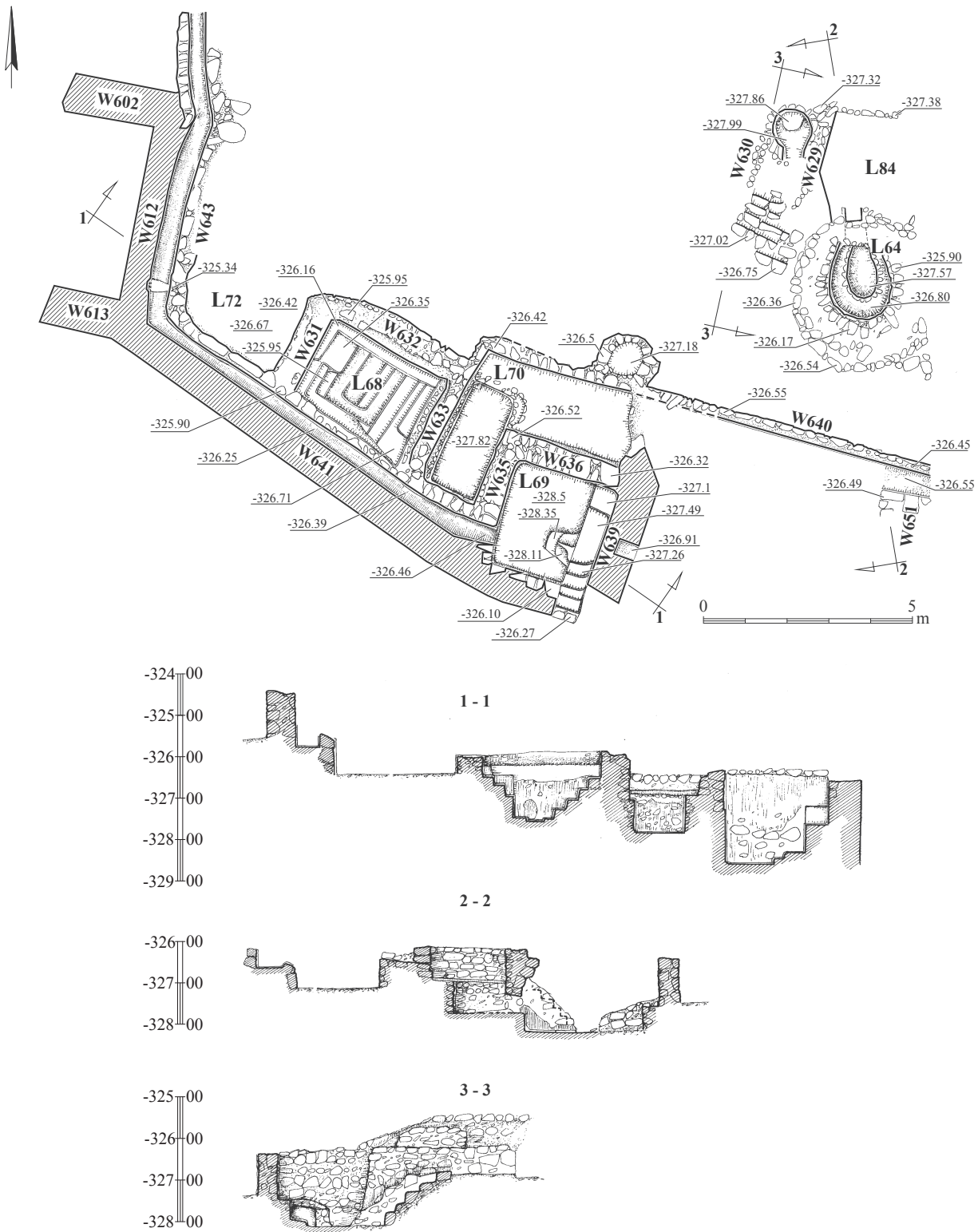


Fig. 104. Water system, plan and cross-sections L68, L69, L70.



Fig. 105. Water system, pool L71 before completion of excavation.



Fig. 106. Water system, pool L71 after completion of excavation.



Fig. 108. Water system, L75.



Fig. 109. Water system, particularly large sedimentation pool for water cistern in Euthymius Monastery. This proves that the large sedimentation pools near L71 are not ritual purification baths.

SITE DESCRIPTION

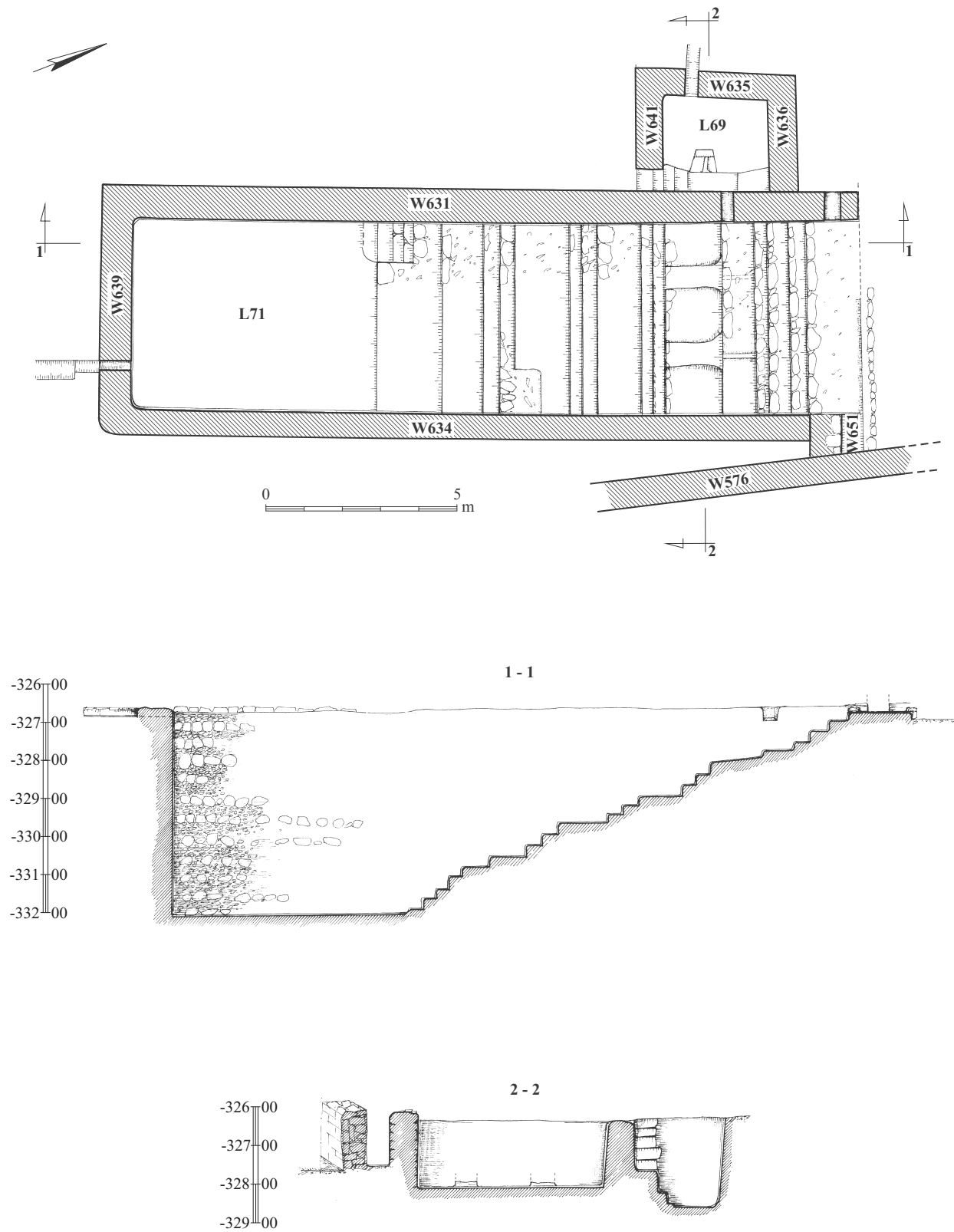


Fig. 107. Water system, plan and cross-sections of pool L71.

site's bounds, the cistern was fed by a narrow covered channel that brought water from the north and passed through sedimentation pool L119. In phase B, when Qumran became a site for clay collection and pottery vessel production, a wide aqueduct was built to receive water from Nahal Qumran and the flow basin north of the site, which it brought to a complex of rectangular pools. A broad open central channel and stepped pools that received the clay were built within the site. The wide phase B channel superseded the phase A channel, and in the wake of its construction, cistern L110 was raised and a new sedimentation pool built. This channel supplied all the stepped pools at the site, and its branch fed cistern L110 from the south. Surplus channels and walled-in areas were built to regulate the quantity of water flowing to the site (Fig. 109).

CEMETERY

The Qumran cemetery is located east of the archaeological site, on a marl slope along the fault scarp formed by the flow of runoff water from the

Judean Desert hills to the Dead Sea. The cemetery is situated in the same area in which the Iron Age and Second Temple-period settlement was built, which is protected on all sides by wadis and the Dead Sea to the east. The graves extend over a number of marl hills east of the site, and it appears that access to the cemetery was from the east, rather than from the site (Fig. 110). The cemetery, that comprises a total of some 1,200 graves, can be divided into three areas: the central area, only a few dozen meters east of the site; the northern area, north of the present-day access road to the site; and the southern area, on the southern bank of Nahal Qumran. All the graves are dug in the marl, with a lateral burial chamber in their bottom. The burial chamber was sealed by mud bricks or stones, with a stone burial mound over the shaft (Fig. 111). The graves were dug in the earth to different depths, some with a north-south orientation, others, random in direction. Remains of a small square structure, that de Vaux called "Point B," were discovered east of the cemetery, on the central marl spur that protrudes eastward.

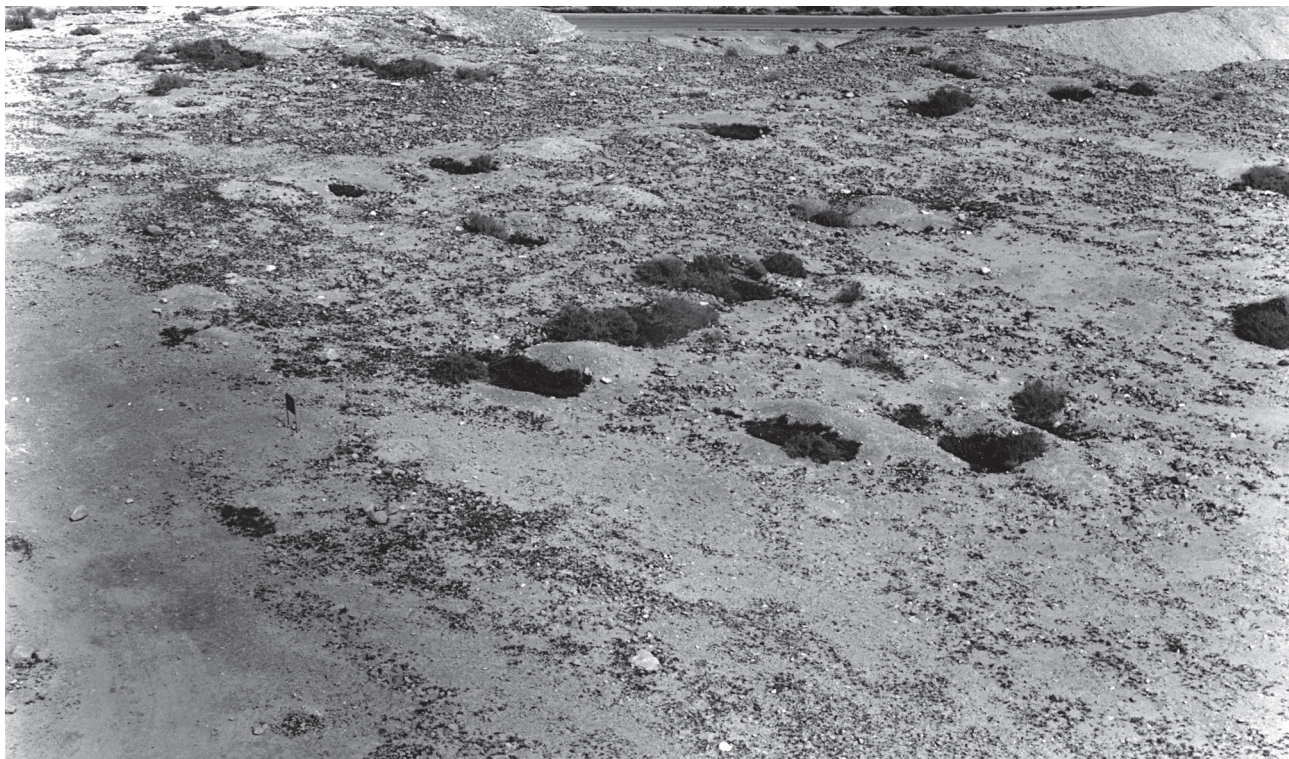


Fig. 110. The cemetery at Qumran, view from the west.

SITE DESCRIPTION



Fig. 111. Graves marked by stone monuments.

Over the course of time, the cemetery was examined by numerous scholars. In the course of his extensive excavations at the site, de Vaux uncovered a large number of graves: 37 graves in the central cemetery,

and an additional 4 in the southern cemetery. He found the bones of those interred, usually without funerary offerings, in all of the graves. Most of those buried were males, but the bones of women and children,

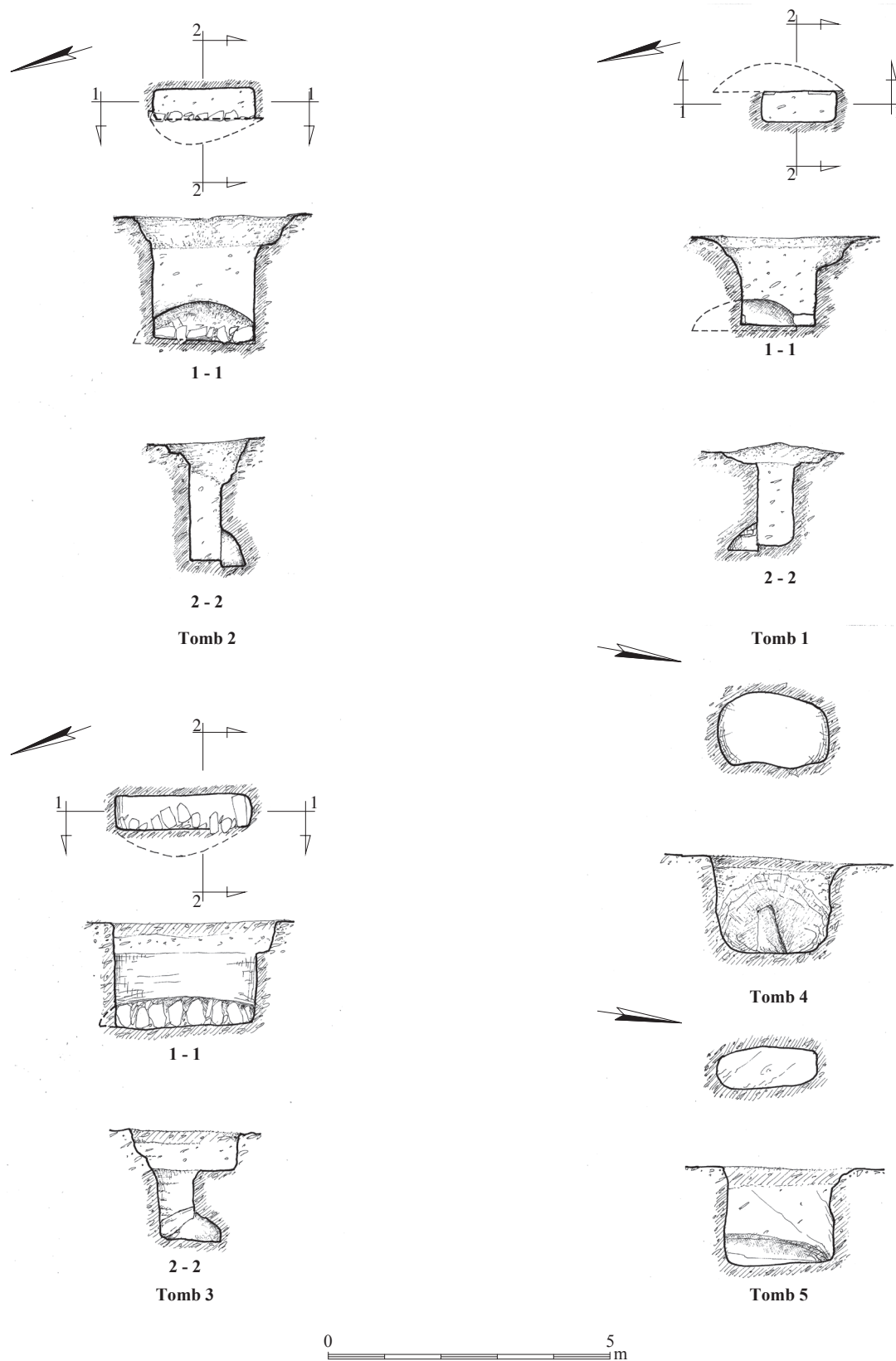


Fig. 112. Graves T-1–5.

SITE DESCRIPTION



Fig. 113. Empty grave containing buried jars sealed with a thick layer of lime. The jars contained date honey.

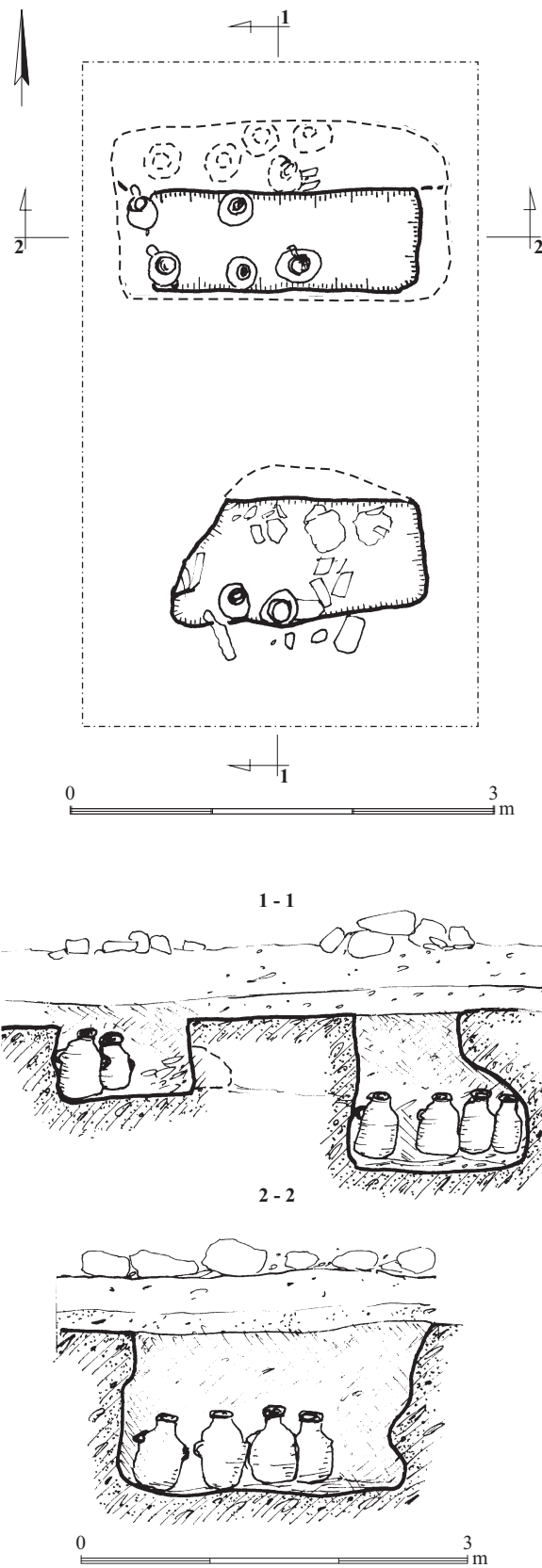


Fig. 114. Graves T-7 containing jars with date honey.

SITE DESCRIPTION



Fig. 115. Sealed jars found in graves.

too, were found. Five of the graves yielded wooden coffins. In some graves, the fill in the shafts contained jar fragments, and even a fragment of a “Qumran lamp” (wheel-made Herodian lamp).

A number of graves contained special finds: Tomb 16 contained the bones of two individuals; and the bones of the individual interred in Tomb 17 were scattered, with the right hand missing. Tomb 32 contained a woman’s bones, with a bronze ring on one of her fingers, and beads next to her foot. Tomb 33 yielded two earrings. Tomb 1, in the southern cemetery, contained a woman’s bones, along with earrings and beads.

In 1966, S. H. Steckoll excavated ten additional graves in the cemetery, one of which was found empty, with no finds or remains of any burial; and in each of two others, he found the bones of a single individual. It is noteworthy that in the first grave excavated he found the skeleton of an adult male who came to a violent end, possibly in warfare (Steckoll 1968; 1969).

In 2001, two graves were excavated by H. Eshel and M. Broshi. One contained pieces of zinc plaques; and in the other, the same square structure excavated by de Vaux, they discovered the remains of two women who had been interred in secondary burial (Broshi and Eshel 2004).

In 2002, nine additional graves, all within the central cemetery, were excavated in the context of the renewed excavations at the site. The anthropological report was written by Yossi Nagar (see “Anthropological Remains” in this volume and Fig. 112).

Grave T1—located in the northeast of the cemetery, in the ridge west of the square structure (Point B). There was a fieldstone burial mound of north–south orientation over the grave. At the bottom of the rectangular shaft cut in the marl is a burial chamber on the east, blocked by four square mud bricks. The burial chamber contained a single male skeleton.

Grave T2—located in the southeast of the cemetery, in the ridge dividing the site from the spur to the east. A fieldstone burial mound of north–south orientation

was over the grave. At the bottom of the rectangular shaft cut in the marl is a burial chamber on the west, blocked by fieldstones. An intact clay bowl was found at the bottom of the shaft. A single male skeleton was discovered.

Grave T3—located adjoining and east of Grave T2. A fieldstone burial mound of north–south orientation was over the grave. At the bottom of the rectangular shaft cut in the marl is a burial chamber on the west, blocked by fieldstones. A single male skeleton was found.

Grave T4—located adjoining and west of Grave T2. A fieldstone burial mound of north–south orientation was over the grave. Under the mound was a rectangular shaft cut in the marl. A few jar body sherds were found in its upper part. The shaft was excavated to its bottom, at a depth of 1.70 m, but no burial chamber was found.

Grave T5—located adjoining and north of Graves T2 and T3. A fieldstone burial mound of north–south orientation was over the grave. Under the stones was a rectangular shaft cut in the marl. The shaft was excavated to its bottom, at a depth of 1.70 m, but a burial chamber was not found (Figs. 113–115).

Grave T6—located west of Graves T2–T5. A fieldstone burial mound of east–west orientation was over the grave. Under the stones was a rectangular shaft cut in the marl. Five jars were found in the shaft, some with a *tzamid patil* (a “tightly sealed cover”). No remains of a burial chamber were discovered.

Grave T7—located adjoining and north of Grave T6. A fieldstone burial mound of east–west orientation was over the grave. Under the stones was a rectangular shaft cut in the marl, in which, and in the burial chamber adjoining it to the north, ten pottery jars were found upright, closed by the “*tzamid patil*” method. No burial remains were found.

Grave T8—located east of Grave T1. A fieldstone burial mound of north–south orientation was over the grave. At the bottom of the rectangular shaft cut in the marl is a burial chamber on the east, blocked by a row of flat stones. The burial chamber yielded a wooden coffin containing a single skeleton, lying on its back with its head in the south and its feet in the north (the skeleton was not examined).

Grave T9—located west of Grave T1. A fieldstone burial mound of east–west orientation was over the

grave. At the bottom of the rectangular shaft cut in the marl was a burial chamber on the north, blocked by a row of large pebbles. A single male skeleton was found in the burial chamber.

The Eastern Structure (“Point B”)—remains of a square structure at the upper end of the central spur that descends eastward from the cemetery. The structure was cleaned by de Vaux, who uncovered the remains of its walls. In his logs he notes that the structure only partially survived, and that the entire southern wall was washed away into the wadi adjoining the spur to the south. At present only the western wall (W782) is visible. It is preserved to a length of 4.50 m, and is built of a single course of medium-sized and large fieldstones. De Vaux’s excavation of the structure unearthed only a few pottery vessel sherds. The purpose of the structure is unclear; it might have been used as a sort of forward observation post for the soldiers garrisoned at the site when the latter functioned as a fortress (early first century BCE).

SUMMARY

Like the other remains, finds, and phenomena found at Qumran, which were immediately thought to be Essene, so, too, the burials at the site. De Vaux and the scholars who followed in his footsteps attributed the graves to the Dead Sea sect, so that every excavated shaft grave with a side burial chamber was ascribed to it, even when discovered in a different area, far from Qumran.

Finds from the Iron Age settlement were discovered at Qumran, and since most of the graves yielded no finds, the cemetery had possibly already been in use in that period. The paucity of finds is typical of single burials. The large number of graves, and the different, including later, periods in which the cemetery was in use, attest that the cemetery was not directly connected with the site. Access to it was probably from the east, rather than through the site. We could hardly assume that the dead were brought through a military installation or a pottery vessel manufacturing center, or through any other type of settlement, including Essene, observing the ritual purity laws, since corpse impurity is the most severe form of impurity, defiling everything with which it comes into contact.